Pelagic

for large ensemble

---

by

Alex Ma

Copyright © Alex Ma 2026. All rights reserved.

Program Notes

duration: ca. 5 minutes

You are alive, and living is enough.

Performance Notes

Conductor
The score is transposed. The section starting at H (m. 107) can go on for as long as you want, but definitely at least 2 minutes from H to the end. Please try to hear at least five different composite melodies before cutting off (you can always wait longer, until you hear more than 5). You may cue each entry individually to come in if you'd like. You can also turn "on" and "off" specific instruments by cuing until the end. Signal the end with some kind of cue, maybe a raised fist and cutoff. You can either cut everyone off at once or turn "off" certain instruments before cutting off.

Make sure to cue the cello and contrabass to come in at this ending section.

All
The final section, starting at H (m. 107) consists of staggered entrances of cells meant to be vamped. The notation suggests one way the section might go. The conductor can tell you to play it that way if they wish to play it that exact way. Otherwise, ignore it and simply repeat your part as long as the conductor requests you to. The main task here is to create composite melodies between your parts. For this, you will have to repeat the same thing a few times. If you feel like you've repeated for long enough, you can also feel free to emphasize/accent specific parts of the repeated pattern (in order to evoke a different composite melody). If you do this, make sure to repeat that changed pattern for a very long time as well.

Winds
Stagger breathe as necessary. Feel free to add slurs while playing. Once you get into the groove of the hocket at H (m. 107), change the slurring patterns to emphasize different notes.

Strings
Stagger bow as necessary. The exception is at mm. 74-92. Here, timing is important. Violin

1, Violin 2, and Viola create a coprime cycle that, after 352 quarter notes,[1] finally ends on the same beat.

Glisses: You don't need to gliss the entire range indicated; you can start from an approximate note on the right string and slide down for effect.

Harmonics: Harmonics are natural harmonics, notated to be the sounding pitch.

En dehors: When annotated *en dehors*, the line is the main melody or in duet, often until the next chord change. For example, Violin I and Violin II play a duet at 45–49, which should have meaningful weight.

Vibraphone
Vibrato is optional. Use pedal. Always let vibrate rather than muting notes.

Harp
Until m. 74, the ostinato should be at a roughly constant dynamic. Let the other instruments wash over you and drown you out before receding. Do observe the dynamics for left hand, however.

A long fade out begins at m. 77. When you get to measures 86 to 87, the ostinato can be more whispered or mimed than played.

Piano
Left hand notated tremolos should be played with fingerings like 5–2–1–5–2–1 in a triplet pattern. Triplet grace notes have been marked as reminders in the score, but even where they aren't marked, please play tremolos this way.

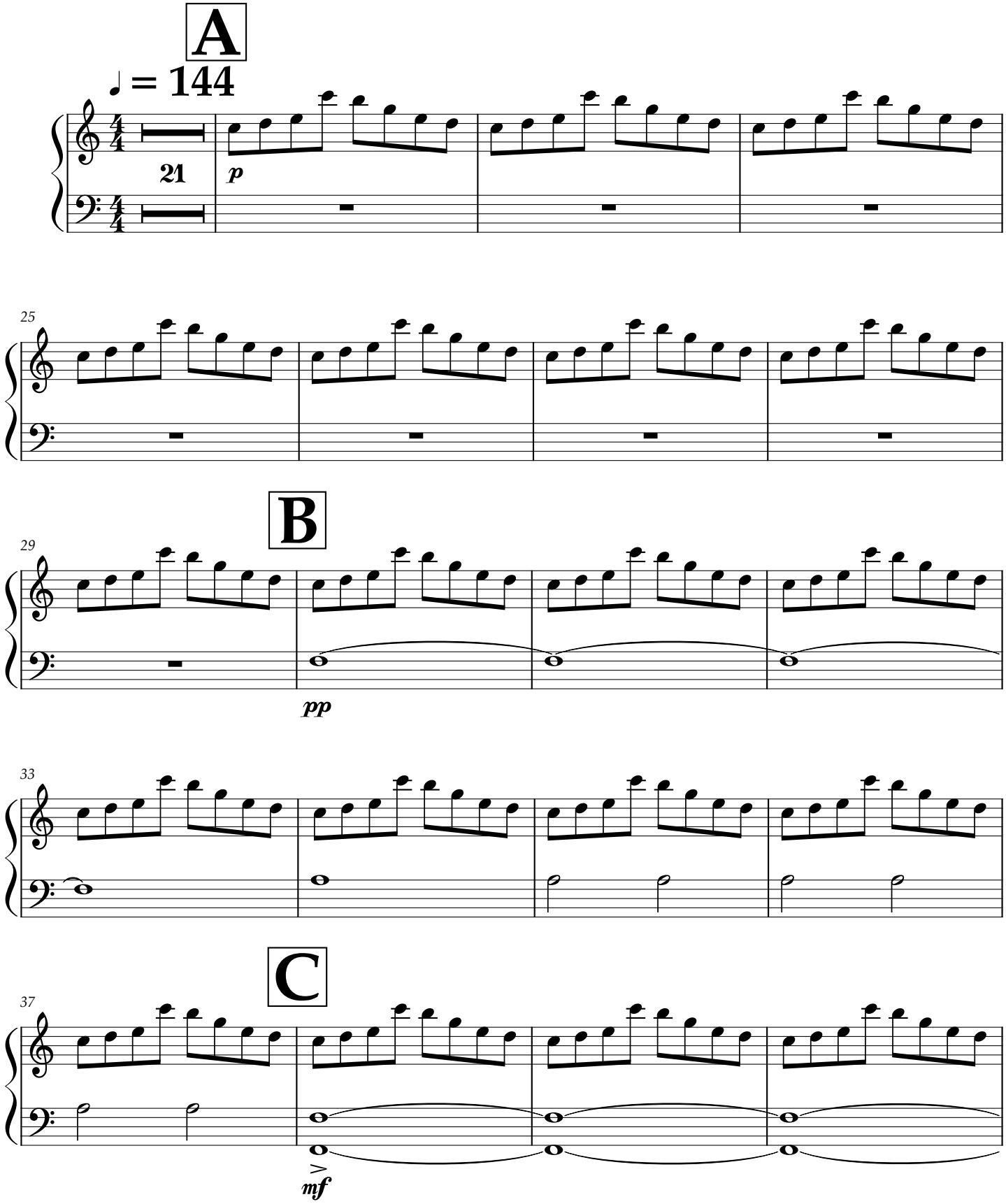
[1] The reason it is not 360 quarters (the least common multiple of 8, 9, and 10) is because we started after the first iteration of the cycle, rather than on last quarter note of m. 71.

Harp

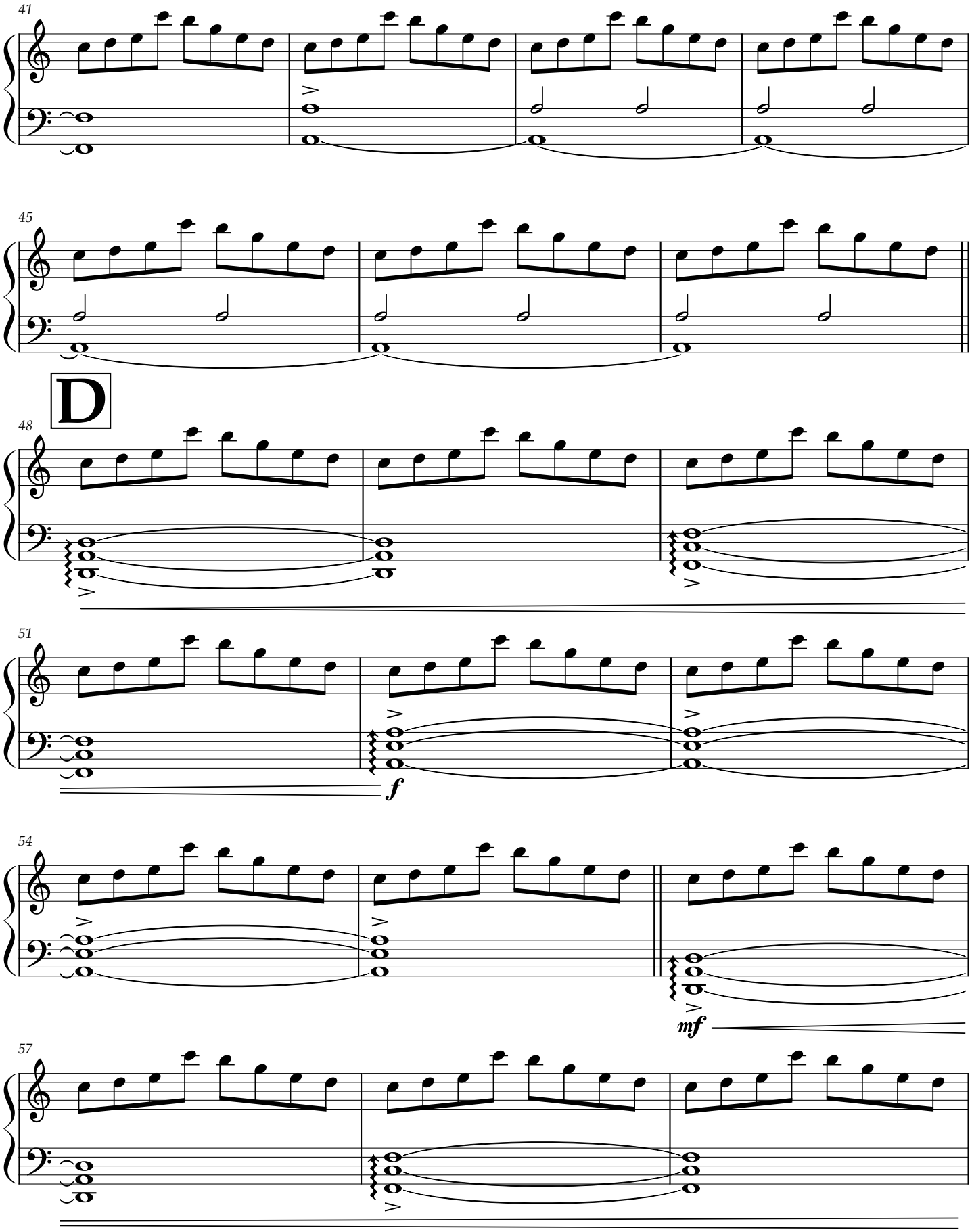
Pelagic

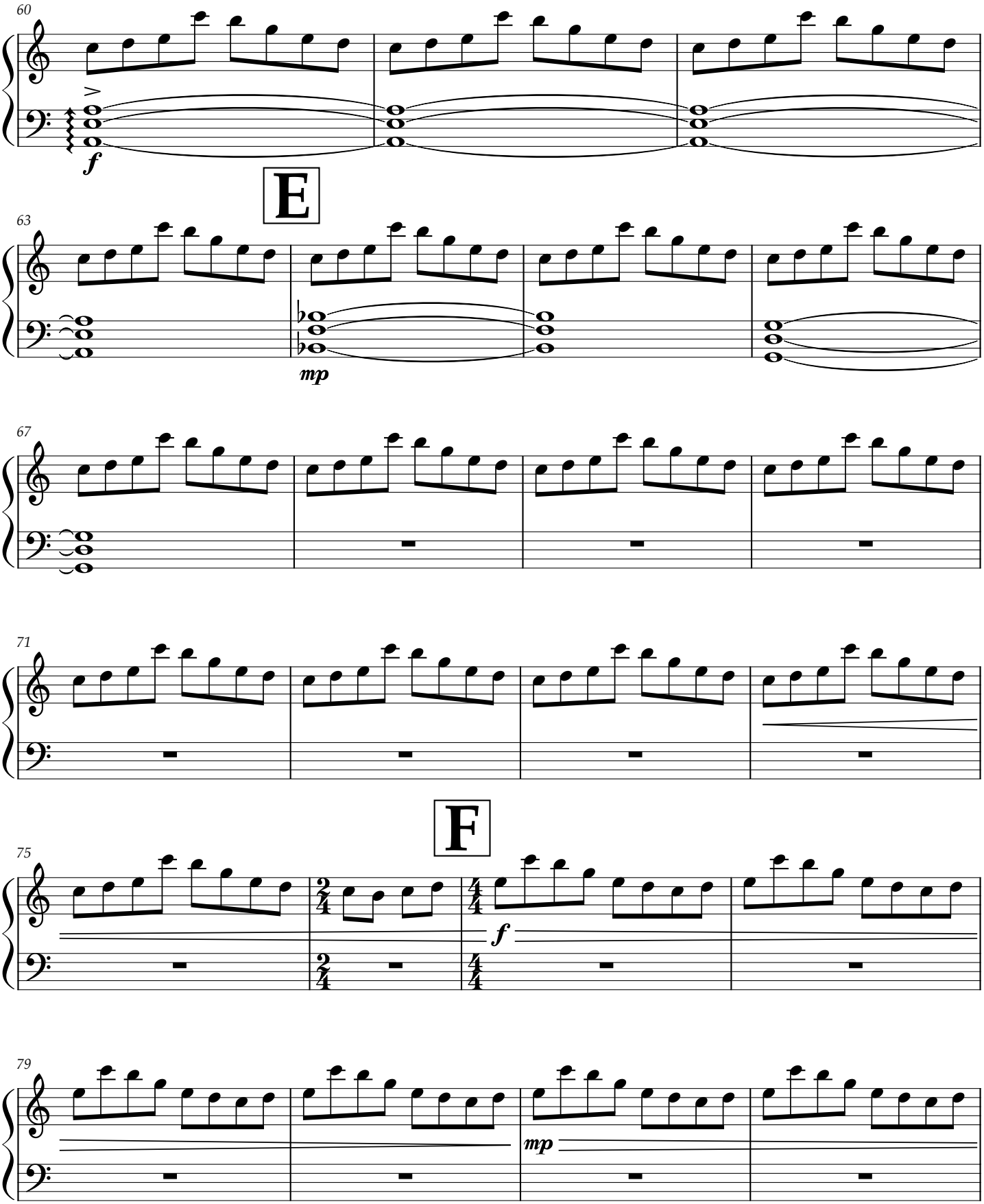
for large ensemble

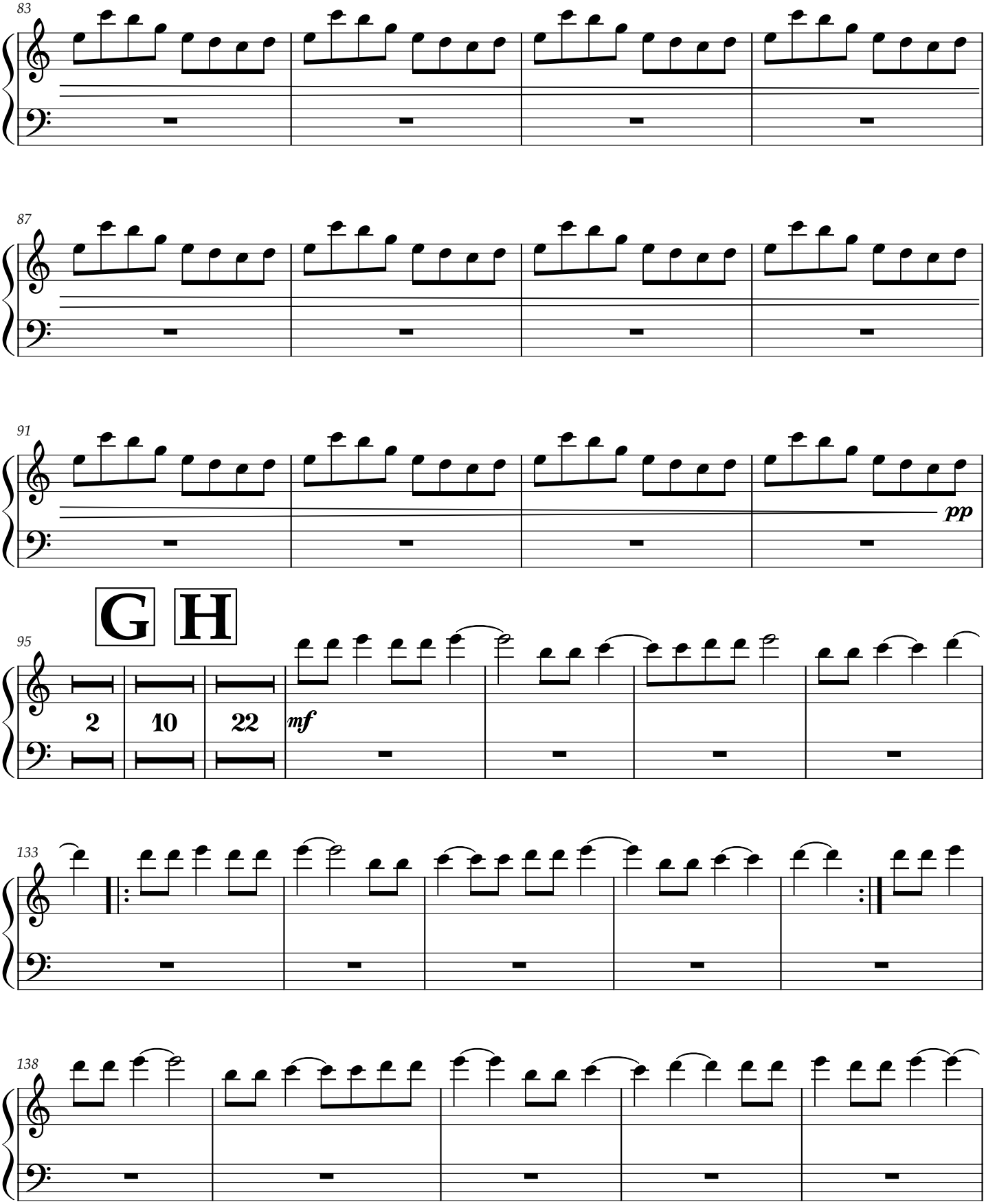
Alex Ma

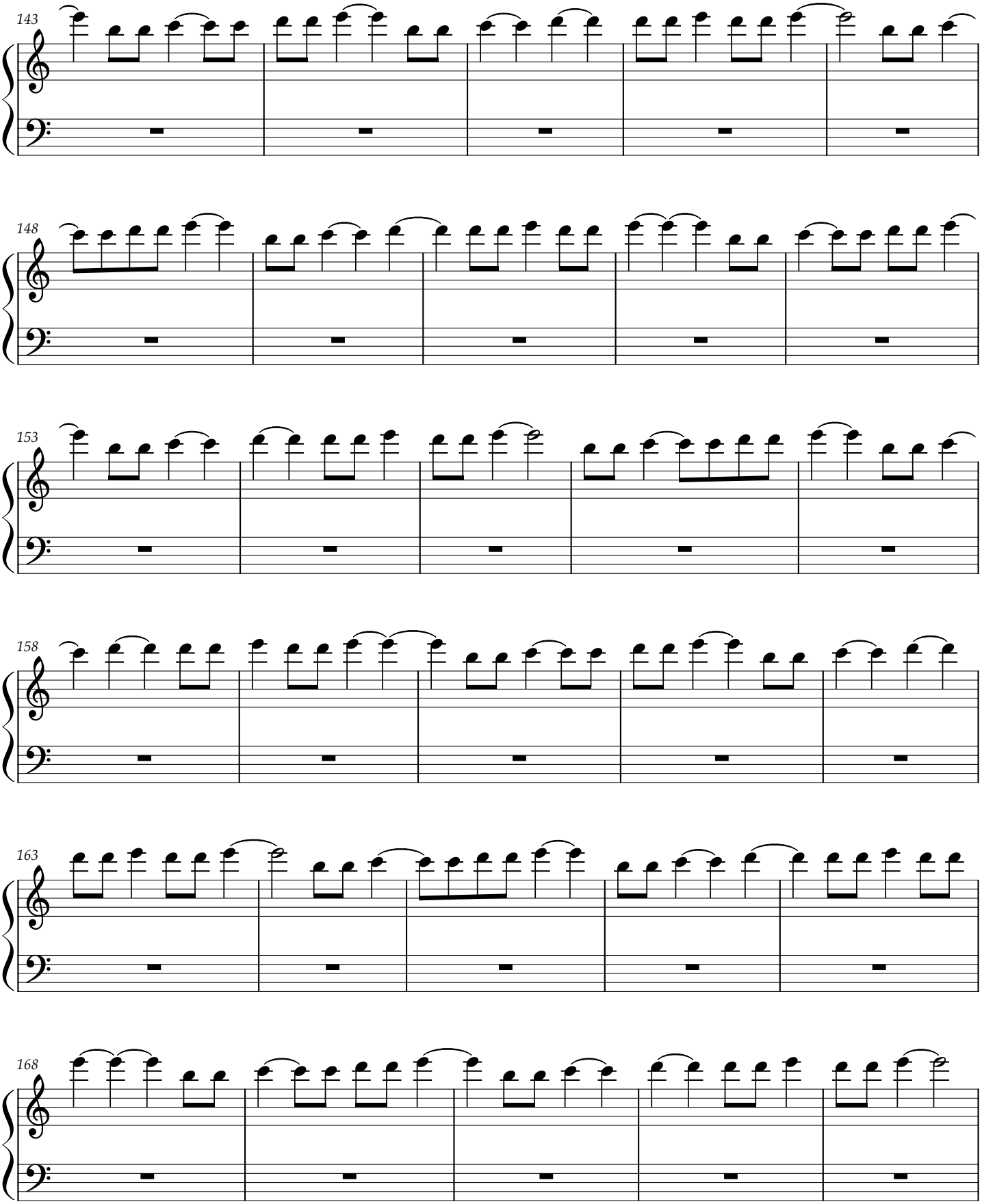


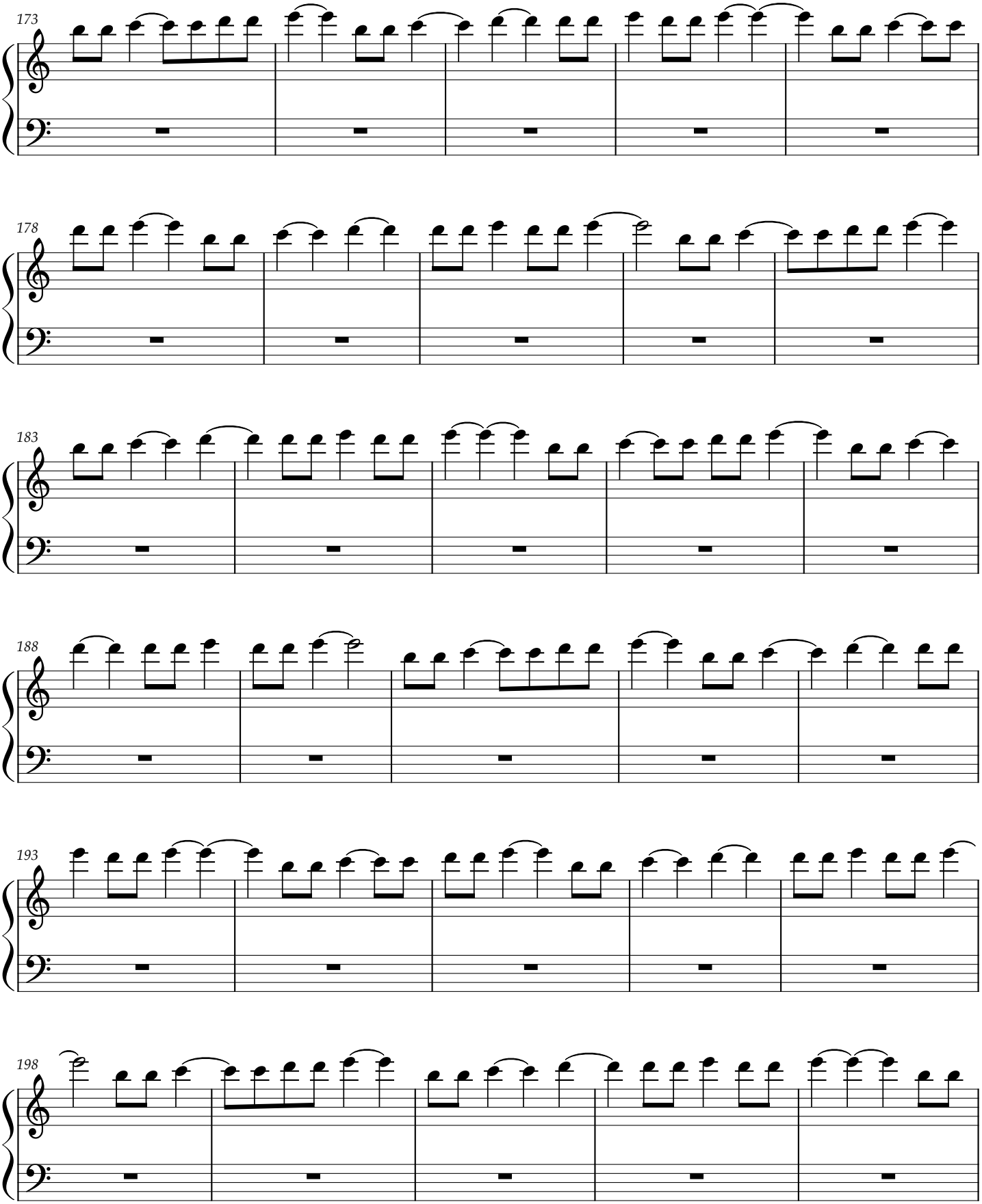
Vers. 2026-04-06

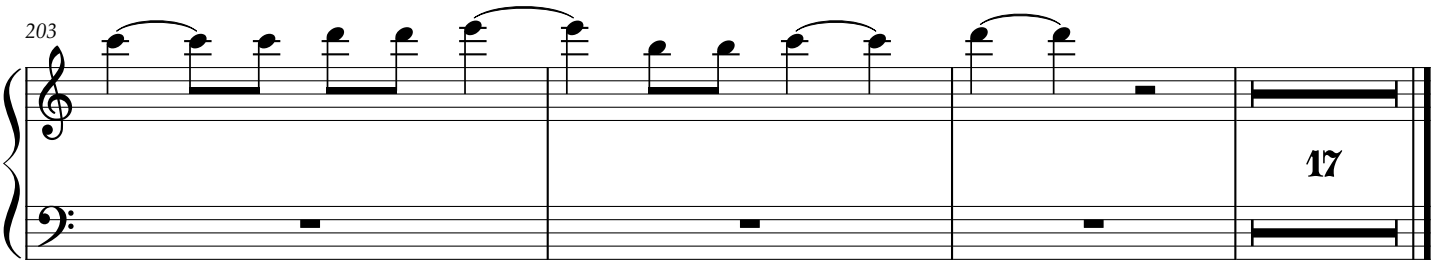

41
45
D
48
51
f
54
mf
57


60
f
E
63
mp
67
71
F
75
f
79
mp


83
87
91
pp
G
H
95
2
10
22
mf
133
138


143
148
153
158
163
168


173
178
183
188
193
198


203
17